market. If the overall trade turnover is growing so rapidly, then the seriousness of our presence cannot be ignored. Currently, India is among the top five trade partners of both Brazil and Argentina. Indian investments are growing apace in diverse sectors, matching the strengthening political collaboration. In the task of making friends and influencing people, Latin America is no longer a bridge too far.

The example of Pacific Islands is a reflection of how much India's reach has extended in the last decade. But it is equally a reminder of what awaits it: a more intensified engagement with regions that are not proximate. Within this period, India has undertaken three summit-level meetings with Pacific Island countries, the most recent being in 2023 in Papua New Guinea. While the warmth of that reception got public attention, what is also important to appreciate is a development agenda that is demand-driven. Much of it focussed on the acute health priorities of the Pacific region. Indian commitments included a super-speciality hospital in Fiji, Jaipur Foot camps, dialysis units and sea ambulances in all member states and centres for supply of cost-effective pharmaceuticals. The digital deficit was also sought to be bridged by creating an IT hub in Papua New Guinea. A warehouse to host geo-spatial data sets was launched, alongside a centre for sustainable coastal and ocean research. Ongoing endeavours at solarization and community skill-building will also be taken forward.

Many Pacific nations were vocally appreciative of Indian assistance during the Covid pandemic, and all of them clearly saw merit in its climate-action initiatives. That Indian calculations have started to focus on a region where there were previously only tenuous contacts obviously speaks of an expanding horizon. But it also underlines how integrated global politics has now become and the importance of extending one's hand generously.

In a different quarter of the world, a similar story has begun to unfold in respect of the Caribbean Community, where there is a significant diaspora as well. Here again, a long-standing but low-key relationship is being energized through development projects, larger investments, enhanced trade and focussed capacity building. Enabling this through a politically-led framework is also beginning to yield results. The Covid pandemic provided an opportunity for India to display solidarity in a manner that will resonate for long.

## NEIGHBOURHOOD: TRULY FIRST